

Trapped in My Head

In elementary school, life is idyllic. The colors are brighter, your friends are nicer, and the biggest worry is whether you can remember your *Wordly Wise* vocabulary for the test after recess. The unfairness of the world isn't revealed until years later when you start to need other news sources besides your mother and father. In fifth grade, I slowly began to move past this stage in life, acquiring a more nuanced understanding of people that lived differently than me. But, when I chose the story *Out of My Mind* by Sharon Draper off of my teacher's towering bookshelf during silent reading, I was exposed to a point of view that I hadn't realized existed, and to this day I still can't completely wrap my head around it.

Out of My Mind focuses on an eleven-year-old girl named Melody Brooks who was born with cerebral palsy. Melody is unable to walk, talk or take care of herself, and relies completely on her parents and caregiver to keep her clean. To communicate with those around her, she uses boards with words, pointing at each to string phrases and sentences together. Her mind is unaffected, in fact, she is extremely intelligent and much more mature than her peers, but the difficulty of expressing herself is unimaginable.

As I read through the obstacles that Melody faced, my fifth-grade self's heart ached. Draper expertly crafted a story showing the reader how almost everyone close to Melody underestimates her, assuming that due to her physical disability, the pace of the gears and cogs spinning in her mind were slowed as well. I remember asking my parents if we knew anyone similar to Melody, and the idea of being trapped in one's body truly frightened me. My ability to speak instead of relying on those around me to communicate is something I had taken for granted until I encountered this novel, and it permanently altered how I conversed with people with disabilities.

After fifth grade, the emotions evoked in me through Draper's storytelling went untouched for about five years, as they collected dust in the back of the attic of my brain. However, I revisited this story's themes when I spent a week at Camp Wamp this past summer. Nestled in the dusty forests of Soda Springs sat a clump of cabins, cots, and eight concrete showers with a thin white curtain pulled over each. This community was constructed upon the side of a lake sparkling from the bright sunbeams reflecting off of it, with a sandy beach on the side of the body of water closer to the cabins. I stepped out of my mom's car, taking in my surroundings and preparing myself for the week ahead. Camp Wamp was a place unlike anything you could imagine. On the surface, it might have looked like any other typical summer camp, but it was filled with some of the most kind-hearted and genuine people I have ever met.

The sanctuary was founded by Steve Wampler — the first person with cerebral palsy to climb El Capitan — after he was forced outside of his comfort zone in his own summer camp experiences as a child. On our first day, he told us his story of the challenges he faced, such as sleeping on the ground and using the bathroom outside of his home. It was for this reason that every camper and counselor slept on cots under the stars, keeping the week-long journey as authentic as possible, as Steve wanted them to be inspired by their own perseverance as he had by his. I quickly fell into a routine during my time there, alternating between washing dishes, preparing the kitchen for meals, and hanging out with the campers. (It's not challenging to guess which activity I enjoyed the most.)

I met a wide variety of people during my time there, but without a doubt the two that had the greatest impact on me were a pair of brothers named Chase and Carson,

respectively ten and eleven years old. I had heard from all of the counselors that they were by far the funniest campers, and I was excited to speak with them and introduce myself.

However, I was a bit confused on how to talk with them, as just like Melody, they both were affected by severe cases of cerebral palsy. Neither of them could speak or walk, and they traveled along the rocky trails of the camp in two stylish electric wheelchairs. I have to admit that looking back on my first encounter, it's quite clear that I was unknowingly afflicted by my personal biases. In my head, I made the shameful assumption that because they were disabled physically, their minds must function differently than mine as well. I'm not sure I could have been proven wrong quicker. Their fingers flew towards their tablets whenever someone walked near them, eager to talk about anything and everything. They pressed away, stringing common words together along with some phrases specialized to their lives, such as their favorite foods or a movie they had watched recently.

When the tablet didn't have the necessary vocabulary to keep the conversation flowing, an older counselor named Ella taught me a trick to add in new ideas if the available words were becoming stale. I'd hold out both of my hands and assign an option to each one, letting them pick one. For instance, that morning Carson was wearing Spider-Man pajamas, so I asked him, "Who do you like better—Spider-Man or Superman?" As I said each name, I placed each of my hands forward. When he gestured towards my right hand, which had been held out when I said Spider-Man's name, I repeated the process. This time, one hand was to tell me that he had watched the newest movie, and the other signaled that he hadn't.

As I laid in my cot that night staring at the stars, brighter than I had ever seen before, I reflected on my first day at camp. That was when the memories of Draper's novel came flooding back to me, as I recalled the sorrow I felt for Melody when her classmates and teachers had underestimated her while she was the smartest in the room. In the solitude of the forest, it occurred to me that I was no better than Melody's classmates that I had been so frustrated with while immersing myself in the story of *Out of My Mind*.

From that point on, my volunteering at Camp Wamp was done with an increased thoughtfulness, and a greater awareness of who I was talking to and how I could help them. None of these kids were looking for anyone to save them, in fact, they were some of the bravest people I've met. I had made an unprincipled mistake, but I decided to learn from my errors and use that motivation to form a deeper bond with the campers. Through my personal experiences at Camp Wamp and Sharon Draper's masterful storytelling in her novel *Out of My Mind*, I was able to recognize my unconscious biases and alter my mindset, becoming a more empathetic counselor and friend.